Who is affected by unemployment? Youth, gender and the long-term unemployed, September 2026

> The unemployment rate is 4.7% but it is not shared evenly: young people are about 2.4 times as likely to be unemployed as the average worker, and almost one in four unemployed people has been looking for a year or more.

4.72%
Unemployment rate, September 2026 (seasonally adjusted); 4.43% a year earlier

11.12%
Unemployment rate, ages 15 to 24 (10.47% a year earlier)

15.92%
Unemployment rate, ages 15 to 19 (15.44% a year earlier)

4.82% / 4.61%
Male / female unemployment rate

22.9%
Long-term unemployed (one year or more), share of all unemployed

167,700
Long-term unemployed people (107,600 in September 2023)

1. Unemployment by group, September 2026

Group (seasonally adjusted)	Sep 2026	Sep 2025	Sep 2023
All people, 15 and over	4.72%	4.43%	3.55%
Males	4.82%	4.65%	3.51%
Females	4.61%	4.18%	3.60%
Aged 15 to 64	4.78%	4.50%	3.60%
Aged 15 to 24	11.12%	10.47%	7.89%
Aged 15 to 19	15.92%	15.44%	11.26%
Teen males / teen females (15 to 19)	17.09% / 14.84%	16.01% / 14.88%	11.63% / 10.89%

- **Youth:** the youth rate is more than double the national rate. Young people have less experience and hold more casual and part-time jobs, so they are laid off first and take longer to find work. The participation rate of 15 to 19 year olds is 58.9% because many are in school.
- **Gender:** the female unemployment rate is now lower than the male rate. The female employment-to-population ratio is 60.2% against 67.2% for males, so the gap shows up in who is employed, not in the unemployment rate.

2. Duration: the long-term unemployed

Measure (seasonally adjusted)	Sep 2026	Sep 2025	Sep 2023
Total unemployed (000)	732.0	676.8	519.5
Unemployed one year or more (000)	167.7	140.6	107.6
Long-term unemployment ratio (% of unemployed)	22.9%	20.8%	20.7%
Ratio: males / females	25.5% / 20.0%	21.1% / 20.4%	22.7% / 18.6%

- **Costs of long-term unemployment:** lost skills, lower future income and lost output for the economy. It is the target of labour market programs, which links to 4F.5.
- **Overall trend:** total unemployment has risen from about 520,000 in September 2023 to about 732,000 in September 2026, and the unemployment rate from 3.55% to 4.72%.

Exam angle: when asked who is affected, name groups (youth, long-term unemployed) and use a figure for each. Link to causes: cyclical unemployment affects young entrants most, and structural unemployment shows up in long duration. Do not assert a cause for the rise from these data alone.

Syllabus link

HSC 2009 Topic 3 (3B Unemployment): 3B.5 the main groups affected by unemployment. Also supports 3B.2 types and causes, 3B.3 costs and 4F.5 education, training and employment programs.

Try this

1. Identify the group with the highest unemployment rate. (1 mark)
2. Outline TWO costs of long-term unemployment. (4 marks)
3. Explain why youth unemployment is higher than the average. (3 marks)

Sources: ABS, Labour Force, Australia, September 2026 (cat. 6202.0), time series spreadsheets: table 1 (all persons), tables 12, 13 and 16 (age groups) and table 25 (duration of unemployment).